

# CHRISKMAS

(The Risks of Christmas)

**Blue denotes PPT slide**

**Brown denotes instructions to technician**

**TEXT:** Luke 2:8-11 (NKJV) *“And there were in the same country shepherds abiding in the field, keeping watch over their flock by night. 9 And, lo, the angel of the Lord came upon them, and the glory of the Lord shone round about them: and they were sore afraid. 10 And the angel said unto them, Fear not: for, behold, I bring you good tidings of great joy, which shall be to all people. 11 For unto you is born this day in the city of David a Saviour, which is Christ the Lord.”*

**INTRO:** Our world is filled with risk taking. We take risks every single day of our lives. You took a risk getting here today.

Nowhere is risk taking accentuated more than in the Christmas story. Everywhere you look in this story, someone is taking a risk. Over the next few weeks I want us to look at the risks these individuals took and how it played out on the screen of their lives. I also want us to take a fresh look at the risks we should take in fulfilling the Great Commission.

The Christmas story is the telling of the story of the incarnation of God. The incarnation is very difficult for us to grasp because it is an explanation of how Jesus was 100% God and 100% man simultaneously. Galatians 4:4 (KJV) *“But when the fullness of time was come, God sent forth his Son, made of a woman, made under the law.”* (LEAVE SCRIPTURE ON SCREEN UNTIL THE END OF BULLET POINTS)

This is difficult for us to get our hands around but:

- God's Son became Mary's Baby...
- A child was born, but a son was given....
- The Lion of the Tribe of Judah became a lamb slain from the foundation of the world... (From everlasting to everlasting – Eternal Priesthood after the order – Before Abraham was, I am)
- An equal to God became a lowly servant of all mankind...
- The Ancient of Days became an infant born in the stable of Bethlehem...
- The Omnipotent became a dependant life to be fed, clothed and nourished by human hands...
- He placed himself in the hands of man, that man might place himself in the hands of God... (Cast ourselves upon the mercies of God – His mercies are new every morning)

- He became sin so the sinful could be forgiven...
- He was bruised so we could be healed...
- He endured turmoil so we could have peace...
- He was rejected so we could be accepted...
- He came to earth so we could go to heaven...
- He became hungry so the hungry could be fed...
- He became thirsty so the thirsty could be satisfied...

## **(TAKE SCRIPTURE OFF SCREEN)**

The truth is, God took a risk when He allowed His Son to become a human being, be raised by earthly parents and interact with an earthly family.

### **I. THE RISK GOD TOOK...**

Luke 2:8-11 (NKJV) *“And there were in the same country shepherds abiding in the field, keeping watch over their flock by night. 9 And, lo, the angel of the Lord came upon them, and the glory of the Lord shone round about them: and they were sore afraid. 10 And the angel said unto them, Fear not: for, behold, I bring you good tidings of great joy, which shall be to all people. 11 For unto you is born this day in the city of David a Saviour, which is Christ the Lord.”*

What a shock it must have been to those shepherds tending sheep on the Judean Hills to suddenly experience such a supernatural phenomena. Shepherds were not used to being on the cutting edge of such announcements; they were peasants who usually learned of such things around a campfire, listening to the folklore tales of the ancient dusty past.

The interesting dynamic of that first Christmas was that for many generations throughout the Old Testament, there was always a remnant of Jewish people who waited every single day for Messiah to come.

The Old Testament is full of hundreds of prophecies about the Messiah but after the Old Testament was completed, there were four hundred silent years before Jesus Christ was born, a time where many people gave up waiting.

The conditions into which God sent His son was anything but perfect, in fact it was the riskiest juncture in human history. Morally, spiritually and culturally it was a dark hour when Jesus Christ was born. ***"Darkness covered the earth."*** Just like today, the shadows were deeper in some lands than in others; some minds were more lost and buried in the thick darkness than others

were.

Judaism had passed out of its manhood into its declining years, out of its strength and spirituality into a dreary and lifeless formalism. It had, indeed, escaped from idolatry, and it was free from the worst excesses of the pagan world; but it was far from embracing the idea of a Messiah who would come with healing for the body, soul and spirit of humankind.

It was against this backdrop the shepherds were paid a visit from the angel, and the Glory of God shined around them. The angels greeted the shepherds with a salutation that throws me off a little. They were told: “*Fear not.*”

That’s easy for angels to say, but more complicated for shepherds to do, especially when you connect the angel greeting with the fact that they showed up without

warning and appeared suddenly! Remember, when the angel arrived, He did so in a cloud of *“The glory of God.”*

Those of us who sit here today considering the story of the shepherds, have a difficult time grasping the gravity of what the shepherds were experiencing:

- We have the benefit of the entirety of the Word of God; they did not...
- We know the angels were not there to harm them; they did not...
- We know the angels were delivering good news; they did not...
- We know the rest of the story; they did not...

We could get caught up in the fact that the shepherds entertained an angel, but the real story is what the angel said. *“And the angel said unto them, Fear not: for, behold, I bring you good tidings of great joy, which shall be to all people. 11 For unto you is*



*born this day in the city of David a Saviour,  
which is Christ the Lord.”* **(LEAVE ON  
THE SCREEN UNTIL NEXT SLIDE)**

The real message to the shepherds is really an explanation of why God decided to take such a risk in sending His son into the world: *“Fear not, the savior has come to bring salvation.”*

God knew the risk He was taking was worth doing, because the outcome would bring about the salvation of the human race.

The salvation this child would bring would change the course of religion, but more importantly, the course of humankind.

The change that He would bring would be clearly seen in six distinct ways:

- The nature and the disposition of God...  
This child would mark the end of one

- dispensation of time and the beginning of another – BC vs. AD - Law vs. Grace
- The character and the consequences of sin... Sin would no longer be rolled ahead a year at a time; it would be forgiven once and for all!
  - The approach to God... No more blood of sheep, bulls and goats – One sacrifice for sin forever!
  - The transcendent value of the human soul... God gave all when He gave Jesus – Why? To redeem the soul of fallen man ***“For God so loved the world...”***
  - The beauty and joy of a life of consecration... Under law, man was always doing and never done – Because of this child, man could now rest in the righteousness of God, and allow that righteousness to control behavior!
  - The certainty of future glory, for those who embrace the God of such a risk... Under law one could never be sure his/her eternity had been sealed –

Because of this child, eternity's ticket could be punched - The deal was signed sealed and delivered!

God took an enormous risk in sending His son into the world; will you cast yourself upon His mercy?

## **II. THE RISK MARY TOOK...**

*Luke 1:26-35 (KJV) "in the sixth month the angel Gabriel was sent from God unto a city of Galilee, named Nazareth, 27 To a virgin espoused to a man whose name was Joseph, of the house of David; and the virgin's name was Mary. 28 And the angel came in unto her, and said, Hail, thou that art highly favoured, the Lord is with thee: blessed art thou among women. 29 And when she saw him, she was troubled at his saying, and cast in her mind what manner of salutation this should be. 30 And the angel said unto her, Fear not, Mary: for thou hast found favour with God. 31 And,*

*behold, thou shalt conceive in thy womb, and bring forth a son, and shalt call his name Jesus. 32 He shall be great, and shall be called the Son of the Highest: and the Lord God shall give unto him the throne of his father David: 33 And he shall reign over the house of Jacob for ever; and of his kingdom there shall be no end. 34 Then said Mary unto the angel, How shall this be, seeing I know not a man? 35 And the angel answered and said unto her, The Holy Ghost shall come upon thee, and the power of the Highest shall overshadow thee: therefore also that holy thing which shall be born of thee shall be called the Son of God.”*

Let us take a few moments and put ourselves in Mary’s place. Mary had saved herself for marriage - she was a virgin! She had made the protection of her reputation a very high priority and had never been with a man. Until this moment, the only way a child had

ever been conceived is for a man and a woman to engage in intimate contact.

If the words of the angel were to come to pass, she would lose her reputation and become the object of suspicion, innuendo and gossip.

Think of the questions flooding the mind of Mary:

- How can this be?
- Why am I the one?
- What about Joseph?
- What will people think?
- Who will believe this story?

The words of the angel were over the line of human impossibility! Yet, listen to the admonition of the angel. ***“Fear not, Mary: for thou hast found favour with God.”*** The angel was asking Mary to step into an arena that no human being had ever ventured into

in the history of the world! Mary was about to:

- Go off the chain...
- Travel beyond the map...
- Sail into uncharted waters...
- Traverse the limits of human history...
- Test the very limits of human impossibility...

Yet, Gabriel says to her, *“The Holy Ghost shall come upon thee, and the power of the Highest shall overshadow thee: therefore also that holy thing which shall be born of thee shall be called the Son of God.”*

**(PLACE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL THE END OF THE BULLET POINTS)**

Notice three very important things:

- The Holy Ghost was to come upon Mary...
- The power of the Highest was to overshadow Mary...

- The Son of God would be the result of the arrangement between Heaven and Earth...

Galatians 4:4 (KJV) *“But when the fullness of time was come, God sent forth his Son, made of a woman, made under the law.”*

Mary faced up to the overwhelming onslaught of human impossibility and gave birth to the Messiah. God anointed Mary to walk the trail of difficulty so that she could experience the reality of the greatest miracle the world would ever know.

The risk Mary was called upon to embrace had the upside potential to change the course of human history. In fact, the miracle that was afoot when Mary was called into the picture was of such proportion that it defied human logic and would become the brainteaser of all time! The name of the baby Mary would give birth to would be

***“Immanuel”*** because it was an act of God donning a human body. As a result:

- On His Mother’s side He became hungry; on His Father’s side He was the Bread of Life and could feed five thousand men with five biscuits and two pieces of fish...
- On His Mother’s side he begged a woman of ill repute for a drink of water; on His Father’s side He created the oceans and the fountains of the deep...
- On His Mother’s side He wept at the tomb of His friend Lazarus; on His Father’s side He called Lazarus back to life...
- On His Mother’s side it was necessary to maintain hydration; on His Father’s side He offered water that would quench thirst for time and eternity...
- On His Mother’s side He was thirty years old when He entered public ministry; on His Father’s side He was present when the morning stars sang



together and the sons of God shouted for joy... (Where was Jesus from 12-30?)

- On His Mother's side He was thirty-three and one half years old; on His Father's side He was the Ancient of Days...
- On His Mother's side He died an early death; on His Father's side He abolished death...
- On His Mother's side He was buried in a borrowed tomb; on His Father's side He is the Resurrection and the Life...
- On His Mother's side He was subject to His parents; on His Father's side God gave Him the name above all other names...
- On His Mother's side He rode a donkey or walked everywhere He went; on His Father's side He rides on the wings of the wind...
- On His Mother's side He used a candle to dispel the darkness of night; on His Father's side He lit the world three days

before He created the sun, moon and stars...

- On His Mother's side He could not light one room at a time; on His Father's side He is the light of a city that is built two thousand miles square...
- On His Mother's side He could only be in one place at a time; on His Father's side He is omnipresent...
- On His Mother's side He had to rely upon the facts He could see; on His Father's side He is omniscient...
- On His Mother's side He broke under the weight of the cross; on His Father's side He is omnipotent...
- On His Mother's side He was a lamb led to His own slaughter; on His Father's side He was the Lion of the Tribe of Judah...
- On His Mother's side He did not open His mouth in His own defense; on His Father's side He possessed the power to

call twelve legions of angels to His own rescue...

- On His Mother's side He tolerated injustice and aggression; on His Father's side He treads out the wine press of the wrath of God and breaks mighty armies across His knees...
- On His Mother's side He was Jesus, Mary's boy; on His Father's side He is King of Kings and Lord of Lords...
- On His Mother's side He never had his name in lights; on His Father's side He will reign forever...
- On His Mother's side He was never elected to high office; on His Father's side He will rule over Heaven and Earth...
- On His Mother's side He was of no reputation; on His Father's side every knee shall bow and every tongue shall confess He is Lord to the glory of God the Father...

The risk Mary took was mind-boggling! The breadth of her actions could not have been properly assessed by this peasant girl from Nazareth, but the truth is, we do not need to know the details of our call to risk-taking, we just need to trust the God who has called us to take this leap of faith!

The impossibility we face today is making a place for a miracle of God to be brought to fruition in our lives. Will history record that we were holy risk takers, or will it record that we chickened out in the face of adversity? **(PLACE SCRIPTURES ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME AS I TALK ABOUT THEM)** Psalm 78:9 (CEV) *“The warriors from Ephraim were armed with arrows, but they ran away when the battle began.”*

We do not need to be chickens like the sons of Ephraim; God will assist those who will take a stand for Him. Psalm 121:1-5 (NKJV)

*“I will lift up my eyes to the hills— From whence comes my help? <sup>2</sup> My help comes from the LORD, Who made heaven and earth. <sup>3</sup> He will not allow your foot to be moved; He who keeps you will not slumber. <sup>4</sup> Behold, He who keeps Israel shall neither slumber nor sleep. <sup>5</sup> The LORD is your keeper; The LORD is your shade at your right hand.”*

Deuteronomy 33:26-29 (NKJV) *“There is no one like the God of Jeshurun, Who rides the heavens to help you, And in His excellency on the clouds. <sup>27</sup> The eternal God is your refuge, and underneath are the everlasting arms; He will thrust out the enemy from before you, And will say, ‘Destroy!’ <sup>28</sup> Then Israel shall dwell in safety, The fountain of Jacob alone, In a land of grain and new wine; His heavens shall also drop dew. <sup>29</sup> Happy are you, O Israel! Who is like you, a people saved by the LORD, The shield of your help and the*

*sword of your majesty! Your enemies shall submit to you, and you shall tread down their high places.”*

**Song: Standing**

### **III. THE RISK JOSEPH TOOK...**

*Matthew 1:18-25 (KJV) “Now the birth of Jesus Christ was on this wise: When as his mother Mary was espoused to Joseph, before they came together, she was found with child of the Holy Ghost. 19 Then Joseph her husband, being a just man, and not willing to make her a public example, was minded to put her away privily. 20 But while he thought on these things, behold, the angel of the Lord appeared unto him in a dream, saying, Joseph, thou son of David, fear not to take unto thee Mary thy wife: for that which is conceived in her is of the Holy Ghost. 21 And she shall bring forth a son, and thou shalt call his name Jesus: for he shall save his people from*

*their sins. 22 Now all this was done, that it might be fulfilled which was spoken of the Lord by the prophet, saying, 23 Behold, a virgin shall be with child, and shall bring forth a son, and they shall call his name Emmanuel, which being interpreted is, God with us. 24 Then Joseph being raised from sleep did as the angel of the Lord had bidden him, and took unto him his wife: 25 And knew her not till she had brought forth her firstborn son: and he called his name Jesus.”*

If you were given the opportunity to meet any person in the first Christmas story, whom would you choose? There are so many fascinating people:

- Herod... A wicked King, jealous of a Baby in a manger.
- The Magi... The Wise Men from the East.
- The Innkeeper... Out of room and probably out of patience.

- The Shepherds... They may have been teenagers, nearly all the shepherds in modern Israel are teenagers; many of them are girls.
- Anna... The prophetess.
- The angels... What an announcement.
- Zacharias and Elisabeth... The father and mother of John the Baptist.
- Mary... The mother of Jesus, what a woman.
- Simeon... Who took baby Jesus in his arms and blessed his parents.
- Joseph – Joseph??? I almost forgot about Joseph!

Joseph is an all but overlooked figure in this story, but the part he played in this epic event is unforgettable. The role of Joseph in all of this was to be the husband of Mary and the foster father of Jesus. I would love to have the opportunity to meet Joseph. What an interesting conversation that would be! I have lots of questions for Joseph:



- How did you handle the announcement?
- How difficult was it to withstand the insults?
- Did you ever consider making a dash for the door?
- How did this affect the rest of your life going forward?

Joseph is the forgotten character of the Christmas story. It appears that Joseph rubbed himself down with invisible cream; he vanished from the story after his initial visit with the angel.

Very little is said about Joseph in the Bible. Rarely ever is a sermon preached about him. As a matter of fact, there's just not much written about Joseph at all.

This is what we know about Joseph:

- His father was Jacob...
- His ancestral hometown was Bethlehem...

- He lived in Nazareth...
- He was from the royal line of David...
- He was a carpenter by trade...
- He was a poor man... We know that because when he and Mary presented Jesus in the Temple, they brought a turtledove to sacrifice. Jews only did that when they could not afford a lamb.
- He was a religious man...
- He was probably in his late teens...

Mary and Joseph were engaged, yet her announcement to him was that she was pregnant! Pregnant? Really? The one thing Joseph knew for sure was that he was not the father!

This could only mean one thing - she had been unfaithful to their commitment to each other. The initial pain must have felt like a ton of bricks falling on him.

(ILLUSTRATION – Doing the job alone)

Joseph had a decision to make - he could have her stoned to death; he could very privately break his engagement with her; or he could marry her. To marry her would be to take an enormous risk!

Was Joseph:

- Angry?
- Shamed?
- Confused?
- Embarrassed?
- Disappointed?

Have you ever wondered, what did he say to her? Better yet, what did she say to him? Did she tell him about the angel Gabriel? If she did, can you blame him for not believing her?

Put yourself in Joseph's shoes. You're a teenager in love and suddenly your girl friend turns up pregnant. You aren't the father but you don't know who is. What do

you do? If you're a typical American teenager, you give her \$200 to go get an abortion. It's easy, it's quick, it's cheap and just like that, you can make the problem go away. A half-million teenage girls take that option every year! It's the preferred solution for what people call an "unwanted pregnancy."

Thankfully, Joseph and Mary didn't have that option, abortion was very rare in ancient Israel and Planned Parenthood hadn't opened up a clinic in Nazareth yet.

Joseph's dilemma was very different, he was a devout Jew, and under the Law he had the right to break his engagement to Mary for unfaithfulness. In fact, the Law forbade him to marry her under those circumstances.

Here is the greatness of Joseph: he loved Mary so much that even though she had made the horrible announcement of her

pregnancy, his thoughts were dedicated to what would be best for her!

Listen to Matthew's description of the actions of Joseph: [Matthew 1:19 \(KJV\)](#)

***“Then Joseph her husband, being a just man, and not willing to make her a public example, was minded to put her away privily.”*** Please understand that this is the posture of Joseph prior to his encounter with the angel! All he had to go on was the word of Mary! Joseph:

- Committed himself to doing the right thing...
- Had no desire to humiliate Mary...
- Decided to deal with Mary privately...

Wow! What a guy! Are there any single women in the room looking for a Joseph? Any of you married women wanting to transition your man into a Joseph?

Joseph first had the right attitude. Then Joseph entertained an angel, and the angel said, *“Joseph, thou son of David, fear not to take unto thee Mary thy wife: for that which is conceived in her is of the Holy Ghost. 21 And she shall bring forth a son, and thou shalt call his name Jesus: for he shall save his people from their sins.”*  
*Matthew 1:20-21 (KJV)*

Think of this: the angel appeared one time to Joseph and spoke less than a paragraph, forty-nine words to be exact, and Joseph immediately responded to a request from Father God to be the foster dad to His Son! What a risk!

If taken, this risk would change everything about Joseph's life forever.

Listen to how readily Joseph responded to the risk of his life, *“Then Joseph being raised from sleep did as the angel of the*

*Lord had bidden him, and took unto him his wife: 25 And knew her not till she had brought forth her firstborn son: and he called his name Jesus.” Matthew 1:24-25*

What a great man of faith and obedience. Most people assume that the story of Joseph ends right there, but it is far from over. From this point on, every action Joseph took testified to his greatness:

- By marrying her quickly he broke all Jewish custom, but he protected Mary's reputation...
- By making sure she remained a virgin until Jesus was born, he protected the integrity of the miracle of Jesus' conception by the Holy Spirit...
- By naming the baby, he exercised a father's prerogative and officially received Jesus into his family, as his own legal son...

In these days of confusion, Joseph is a wonderful model of what a godly risk-taking man looks like:

- He was tough, when he could have been weak...
- He was understanding, when he could have been harsh...
- He was thoughtful, when he could have been hasty...
- He was trusting, when he could have doubted...
- He was temperate, when he could have indulged himself...

Though the angel said, “***Fear not to take Mary to be your wife***”, the onus of that decision rested squarely on the shoulders of Joseph. He was being asked to take the greatest risk of his young life.

Almost always when we are called upon to obey, we do not necessarily understand why. The responsibility is ours to step up to the



fear not of obedience and trust God as we move forward into uncharted territory.

Isaiah 55:9 (NKJV) ***“For as the heavens are higher than the earth, So are My ways higher than your ways, and My thoughts than your thoughts.”***

Philippians 4:6-7 (CEV) ***“Don’t worry about anything, but pray about everything. With thankful hearts offer up your prayers and requests to God. 7 Then, because you belong to Christ Jesus, God will bless you with peace that no one can completely understand. And this peace will control the way you think and feel.”***

We may not understand the risks we are called upon to take, but if we will face each circumstance as Joseph did, God will certainly bring our journey to a good end.

I cannot explain the circumstances, but I accept my present position in life as the will

of God for me. If I am in His will, He will do more with my journey than I can imagine. Ephesians 3:20-21 (NKJV) *“Now to Him who is able to do exceedingly abundantly above all that we ask or think, according to the power that works in us, 21 to Him be glory in the church by Christ Jesus to all generations, forever and ever. Amen.”*

The risks God calls us to take are worth doing! Joseph discovered, and we know, God always exceeds expectations! With God we always get more than we expect:

- He didn't just make a single drop of water; He created oceans of water...
- He didn't create one lone star (No matter what Texan's think); God masterminded and created galaxies...
- He didn't just design a hill; God made mountain ranges...
- He didn't just make the sun; God designed sunsets and sunrises....

When we are called upon to take a risk, we must remember, in God's world there are no limits or boundaries:

- There are no boundaries to His blessings...
- There are no containers that can hold His compassion...
- There are no fences impeding His faithfulness...
- There are no guardrails standing between His grace and us...
- There are no lines separating us from His presence...
- There are no limitations to experiencing His life...

If we can step up to the risk He is calling us to, every blessing can be ours!

#### **IV. THE RISK WE ARE CALLED UPON TO TAKE...**

Over the past three weeks we have discussed:

- The risk God took in sending His Son into the world...
- The risk Mary took by agreeing to be the mother of Jesus...
- The risk Joseph took in assuming the role of the earthly father of Jesus...

There are actually many other characters in the Christmas story that we could have pointed to as we attempt to challenge ourselves to be risk-takers.

The Bible is a book about risk-takers. Nothing significant ever happens without a risk being taken. Faith is what moves the hand of God. **Hebrews 11:1-2 (CEV) “*Faith makes us sure of what we hope for and gives us proof of what we cannot see. <sup>2</sup> It was their faith that made our ancestors pleasing to God.*”**

In concluding this series, I want us to take a look at some biblical risk takers and how the risks they took led to great victories:

**(PLACE SCRIPTURES ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Noah took a risk and saved his family, as well as the human race... Hebrews 11:7 (MSG) *“By faith, Noah built a ship in the middle of dry land. He was warned about something he couldn’t see, and acted on what he was told. The result? His family was saved. His act of faith drew a sharp line between the evil of the unbelieving world and the rightness of the believing world. As a result, Noah became intimate with God.”*
- Abraham took a risk and became the father of nations... Hebrews 11:8-10 (MSG) *“By an act of faith, Abraham said yes to God’s call to travel to an unknown place that would become his home. When he left he had no idea where he was going. By an act of faith*

*he lived in the country promised him, lived as a stranger camping in tents. Isaac and Jacob did the same, living under the same promise. Abraham did it by keeping his eye on an unseen city with real, eternal foundations—the City designed and built by God.”*

- Jochebed took a risk and defied the king’s commandment and in so doing she set the wheels of deliverance in motion for a nation... Hebrews 11:23 (NKJV) *“By faith Moses, when he was born, was hidden three months by his parents, because they saw he was a beautiful child; and they were not afraid of the king’s command.”*
- Moses risked everything to emancipate a nation of slaves... Hebrews 11:24-27 (NKJV) *“By faith Moses, when he became of age, refused to be called the son of Pharaoh’s daughter, <sup>25</sup> choosing rather to suffer affliction with the people of God than to enjoy the passing*

*pleasures of sin, <sup>26</sup> esteeming the reproach of Christ greater riches than the treasures in<sup>le</sup> Egypt; for he looked to the reward. <sup>27</sup> By faith he forsook Egypt, not fearing the wrath of the king; for he endured as seeing Him who is invisible.”*

- Esther risked her very life to save her people... Esther 4:13-14 (NKJV) *“Do not think in your heart that you will escape in the king’s palace any more than all the other Jews. <sup>14</sup> For if you remain completely silent at this time, relief and deliverance will arise for the Jews from another place, but you and your father’s house will perish. Yet who knows whether you have come to the kingdom for such a time as this?”*
- John the Baptist took a risk and introduced the Savior to the world... Luke 3:2-6 (MSG) *“John, Zachariah’s son, out in the desert at the time, received a message from God. He went*

*all through the country around the Jordan River preaching a baptism of life-change leading to forgiveness of sins, as described in the words of Isaiah the prophet: Thunder in the desert!*

*“Prepare God’s arrival! Make the road smooth and straight! Every ditch will be filled in, every bump smoothed out, the detours straightened out, all the ruts paved over. Everyone will be there to see the parade of God’s salvation.”*

- The Apostles took a risk and established the New Testament Church... There was a heavy price to pay for their risk taking.
  1. Matthew suffered martyrdom in Ethiopia, killed by a sword wound.
  2. Mark died in Alexandria, Egypt after being dragged by horses through the streets until he was dead.
  3. Luke was hanged in Greece as a result of preaching to the lost.
  4. John faced martyrdom when he was boiled in huge basin of boiling oil during



a wave of persecution in Rome. However, he was miraculously delivered from death. John was then sentenced to work in the mines on the prison Island of Patmos. The apostle John was later freed and returned to serve as Bishop of Edessa in modern day Turkey. He died as an old man, the only apostle to die peacefully.

5. Peter was crucified upside down on an x-shaped cross. According to church tradition it was because he told his tormentors that he felt unworthy to die in the same way that Jesus Christ had died.

6. James was thrown over a hundred foot drop, on the southeast pinnacle of the Temple, because he refused to deny his faith in Christ. When they discovered that he survived the fall, his enemies beat James to death with a club.

Incidentally, this was the same pinnacle where Satan had taken Jesus during his temptation.

7. James, the Son of Zebedee, was ultimately beheaded at Jerusalem. The Roman officer who guarded James watched in amazement as James defended his faith at his trial. Later, the officer walked beside James to the place of execution. Overcome by conviction, the Roman officer declared his new faith to the judge and knelt beside James to accept beheading as a Christian.

8. Bartholomew was martyred for his preaching in Armenia where he was flayed to death by a whip.

9. Andrew was crucified on an x-shaped cross in Patras, Greece. After being whipped severely by seven soldiers they tied his body to the cross with cords to prolong his agony. His followers reported that, when he was led toward the cross, Andrew saluted it and spoke these words: *“I have long desired and expected this happy hour. The cross has been consecrated by the body of Christ*

*hanging on it.*” From his cross he continued to preach to his tormentors for two days until he died.

10. Thomas was stabbed with a spear in India during one of his missionary trips.

11. Jude was killed with arrows when he refused to deny his faith in Christ.

12. Matthias was stoned and then beheaded.

13. Paul was tortured and then beheaded by the evil Emperor Nero at Rome in A.D. 67. Paul endured a lengthy imprisonment, which allowed him to write his many epistles to the churches he had formed throughout the Roman Empire. These letters, which taught many of the foundational Doctrines of Christianity, form a large portion of the New Testament.

Perhaps this is a reminder to us that our sufferings here are indeed minor compared to the intense persecution and cold cruelty

faced by the apostles and disciples for the sake of the Faith.

Risk taking almost always comes with a price tag. What are we willing to risk, and what are we willing to pay?

## **HUMAN VIDEO**